

UX Research Methods Reference

Beacon Field Research | Study Alpha anchor: 2026-07-13 | session UX-184 | planned n=24

Reference frame

Use this guide to plan and conduct **Study Alpha**: a synthetic Beacon Field Research study anchored to 2026-07-13, session UX-184, planned n=24. It is an internal practice reference, not a claim about a real participant population.

The core discipline is simple: record what happened, then label the reasoning that follows. A note can be useful before it is certain, but it must not blur observation and inference.

Study flow

Start each session with purpose, consent language appropriate to the synthetic exercise, and an accessibility check. Move from context to concrete examples, then end with a recap and correction invitation. Do not treat a scripted guide as a fixed order when participant comfort calls for a different pace.

Phase	Researcher action	Evidence produced
Plan	State decision, learning goals, recruitment criteria, and risks.	Versioned guide; assumptions log; sample plan.
Run	Invite demonstration and examples; pause for access needs.	Timestamped observation notes and direct quotations.
Synthesize	Compare evidence, counter-evidence, and uncertainty.	Finding cards with confidence and next question.
Share	Separate evidence from recommendation and decision owner.	Readout with traceable links to notes.

Observation versus inference

Observation is a directly witnessed action, stated phrase, or recorded event. Preserve enough context to make it checkable. **Inference** is an interpretation, pattern, or explanation. It should name its supporting observations and confidence.

Example: Observation: “At 14:07 the participant opened filters twice and said, ‘I expected this to remember me.’” Inference: “Persistent filter state may be unclear.” The first is evidence; the second is a testable explanation, not a fact.

Write it as	Good practice	Avoid
Observation	Who/what/when; quote or action; neutral verbs.	“Confused user” without observable behavior.
Inference	Tentative claim + evidence IDs + alternative explanation.	Presenting a pattern as a direct quote.
Decision	Owner, trade-off, date, and evidence considered.	Calling a preference a validated requirement.

Quality checks

Before a finding is promoted, seek disconfirming evidence, note gaps in coverage, and ask whether moderation could have shaped the answer. A repeated statement is not automatically a generalizable result; it is a signal for further inquiry.

For Study Alpha, keep the session anchor UX-184 and planned n=24 visible in planning materials. Actual completed sessions, exclusions, and access accommodations must be counted separately.